NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 1NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥2

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 6 3 ♥ A K 2 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ A 7 5 2	
♠ K J 10 ♥ Q 7 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ K J 9 6 3	N W E S	♠ Q 8 ♥ J 10 9 8 4 ♦ K 8 7 2 ♣ Q 10
	♠ A 7 5 4 2 ♥ 6 5 3 ♦ 10 6 5 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT		
All Pass			

1NT by North
Lead: ♥J

Here is the question. Is 2♠ a better contract than 1NT? If so, you should transfer partner, then pass. If not, you should just pass now. With just a 5-card suit, and with no singleton, pass is probably better.

The contract would be 1NT played by South.

North plays 1NT. East leads the ♥J and West plays the ♥Q.

Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

Outside ♠s you have 6 combined cards in each suit, so you must assume that you aren't any worse off in ♥s than in one of the minors. And, in ♥s you have 2 stops. So don't hold up.

You need 2 additional ♠ winners, but dummy has but one entry. So?

So you must duck twice. Win the ♥K and play a low ♠ from each hand. A defender will win and probably continue ♥s.

Win the ♥A and play another low ♠ from each hand. East wins and cashes 3 ♥s. He then plays the ♣Q.

You win the ♣A and take the ♦A and the 3 good ♠s in dummy. The 4 high cards from your hand plus the 3 ♠ tricks from dummy add up to 7. Hallelujah.

They say 1NT is the hardest contract to make. (whoever **THEY** are).

But since they may be right you need to be on the lookout for ducking plays because one entry in dummy may be all you are going to have.

Board 2
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 9 7 4 ♥ J 10 7 2 ♦ 9 6 4 3 ♣ 7 2	
♠ 8 5 ♥ Q 6 5 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ A 9 8 6 3	N W E S	♠ A 10 2 ♥ A 8 3 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ K Q J 4
	♠ K Q J 6 3 ♥ K 9 4 ♦ K J 10 ♣ 10 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	Pass	1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠K

It is good to be a little bold with your overcalls. But with a suit this tattered and only two outside Queens this is not good enough for a 2-level overcall. So you pass. Then you hear partner say 1NT.

It is good to be a little bold with your overcalls. But with a suit this tattered and only two outside Queens this is not good enough for a 2-level overcall. So you pass. Then you hear partner say 1NT.

A 1NT overcall shows 15-18 points and a stopper(s) in their suit. With 9 points you invite with 2NT and partner bids the game.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠K. Do you hold up twice? Or just once? Or not at all?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 8

You need to find one winner and it seems that it must come from one of dummy's red Queens. You are certain that South has both red Kings for his opening bid, (you and dummy have 26 HCP between you so that only leaves 14). But you also know that South has at least 5 ♠s, so if you lead toward a red Queen South will grab his red King plus 4 ♠ tricks.

Does that resolve the holdup question for you?

Yes. You hold up **ONCE**, and take the ♠A at trick 2. Next you play ♣ K Q J to strip South of that suit. Then play the ♠10 to throw South into the lead.

He can take his other 3 ♠ winners, but after that he must lead a red card. Of course you confidently put up dummy's Queen which will be your ninth trick.

Hold ups are designed to disrupt enemy communication.

Here you couldn't afford to hold up twice because then you would not have a throw in card left to put South on lead.

But you had to hold up on the first trick to make sure North couldn't gain entry in the suit.

By the way, if South had a 6-card suit this plan wouldn't work. But then, no other plan would either.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 9 7 2 ♥ 6 ♦ 7 4 3 ♣ Q 10 7 4 3	
♠ J 3 ♥ J 9 5 2 ♦ K 6 5 ♣ A 8 5 2	N W E S	♠ Q 6 4 ♥ A 10 8 3 ♦ 10 9 8 2 ♣ 9 6
	♠ A 10 8 5 ♥ K Q 7 4 ♦ A Q J ♣ K J	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♥2

When you have 4 cards in both Majors you respond 2♥ to a Stayman request. Partner now bids 3NT.

When you have 4 cards in both Majors you respond 2♥ to a Stayman request. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner denies having 4 ♥s so he must have 4 ♠s (or he would not have used Stayman). You correct the contract to4♠.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♥2. East grabs the opening lead with the ♥A and plays the ♦10.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

The ♠, ♥ and ♣ losers are inevitable so you'd better not lose a ♦. Even though East has returned a ♦ it is still possible that he holds the ♦K so the finesse has a chance of working. Let's say a 50% chance. Do you take it?

No, of course not. Not when you have a play that offers almost a 100% chance. Win the ♦A, play ♠K, ♠A, then ♥ K Q, discarding dummy's 2 ♦ losers.

With one master trump still out you start on the ♣s, playing first the ♣K, then overtake the ♣J with dummy's ♣Q. The defense is welcome to take their ♣A whenever they want, and they are also welcome to their trump trick. You are so gracious because you have your ten tricks!

Half the time the ♦K will be with East, and the inferior plan of taking the finesse will work. On those Deals your superior plan shows no payoff.

But the other 50% of the time West will have the ♦K. On those Deals you get your just reward.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q J 10 8 ♥ J 7 3 2 ♦ K 9 7 4 ♣ K	
♠ A K 5 ♥ A 9 8 4 ♦ A 8 6 3 ♣ Q 5	N W E S	♠ 7 3 ♥ 6 5 ♦ J 2 ♣ A J 9 8 7 4 3
	♠ 9 6 4 2 ♥ K Q 10 ♦ Q 10 5 ♣ 10 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♠Q

You do have 9 points, of a sort anyway. Hoping your ♣ suit will be of use, you invite with 2NT. Partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♠Q, South following with the ♠2. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

No, don't hold up. At least you have ♠s stopped twice, your other suits are stopped only once.

Realizing that your only hope is for a bunch of ♣ tricks you win the ♠K and play the ♣Q. North covers with the ♣K. What do you do?

If you win with dummy's ♣A, and if the ♣s split 2-2, you can win 7 ♣ tricks and 4 other high cards. Wow!

But if it turns out that the ♣K was singleton you will win just TWO ♣ tricks because dummy has no other entries.

So if you feel like gambling, go up with the ♣A. But if you like the idea of a guaranteed contract let North hold the ♣K, and you make sure of the six other ♣s.

This Deal is not a "made up" one, it was actually played at our Monday Duplicate game in May 2012.

The play went exactly as shown above. When her LHO played the ♣K our declarer ducked in dummy and made the contract.